

AI Agents Explained

FRONTMATTER

title: AI Agents Explained
video no: 16 of 30
series: Building an AI Business From Scratch
voice_reference: ../../Input/4. Resources/2.
scripting_resources/voice_reference/nate_herk_voice_reference.md
video_type: concept
hook_type: Curiosity-Gap
script_versions: A + B
status: DRAFT

REFERENCE VIDEOS

- "I built 500+ AI agents, here's everything I know" (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Svp7fbF0g2I>) -- Nate Herk -- Watch for the practical definition of what makes something an AI agent vs a simple automation -- the distinction most people miss
- Stop Vibe Coding: Context Engineering & RAG for AI Agents (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7zZtxUW6dhc>) -- Cole Medin -- Watch for the technical substrate: context engineering as the foundation of reliable agents
- How Nate Herk's AI Agent Is Revolutionizing Lead Response Times (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fnaTZa0-S30>) -- Nate Herk -- Watch for a real deployed agent in production: inputs, decisions, outputs, human handoff points

THE ONE THING

An AI agent is just a model with tools and a loop -- it perceives, decides, acts, and checks the result. That simple pattern is what makes it fundamentally different from a chatbot.

HOOK

"AI agents" is the most used and least understood term in AI right now. Here is what is actually happening when an agent does something -- behind the scenes, in plain language.

TARGET VIEWER

Someone who has heard "AI agents" constantly but still thinks of them as chatbots with extra steps -- they want to understand the actual mechanism before they try to build one.

PAYOFF

After watching, the viewer can explain what an AI agent actually is, describe the perceive-decide-act loop, identify the difference between a chatbot and an agent, and understand why tool access is the key ingredient.

BEAT STRUCTURE

Beat -- The Overused Word Problem

Point: Every AI product calls itself an "agent" now. That has made the word meaningless for most people. Here is the actual definition -- and why it matters for building.

Visual: Collage of AI products all claiming to be "agents" -- then hard cut to a simple, clean definition on screen

Target words: ~100w

Beat -- The Core Loop

Point: An agent runs a loop: perceive (take in context), decide (choose an action), act (use a tool or write output), observe (check what happened), repeat. This is the mechanism behind every AI agent.

Visual: Animated diagram: the perceive-decide-act-observe loop as a cycle -- then overlay a real example: research agent perceiving a query, deciding to search, acting on the web, observing results, deciding next step

Target words: ~190w

Beat -- Tools -- The Key Ingredient

Point: What makes an agent different from a chatbot is tools: the ability to actually do things -- search the web, read files, call APIs, run code. Without tools, it is just a text generator.

Visual: Split: chatbot (text only, no external action) vs agent (same model + web search + file access + code runner) -- show the output difference on the same task

Target words: ~170w

Beat -- Human in the Loop

Point: The best agents know when to stop and check. A fully autonomous agent that never pauses is often less reliable than one with deliberate human checkpoints at key decisions.

Visual: Workflow diagram: agent running autonomously until it hits a "human review" checkpoint -- then continues after approval. Show where this matters in a real task.

Target words: ~160w

Beat -- What Agents Are Good At

Point: Repetitive multi-step tasks, research synthesis, anything with a clear goal but uncertain path. Agents excel where the steps cannot all be pre-programmed but the destination is fixed.

Visual: Three use case examples: lead response agent, research compilation agent, content pipeline agent -- each with the perceive-act loop visible

Target words: ~130w

Beat -- CTA Bridge

Point: You understand what agents are. Next: AI Rules -- how to control what your agent does and does not do, which is the first thing to configure before any agent runs.

Visual: Preview clip from AI Rules Explained

Target words: ~60w

ANALOGY BANK

- AI agent vs chatbot: Like the difference between a calculator and an accountant -- the calculator gives you an answer when you ask. The accountant takes the problem, figures out what information is needed, goes and gets it, does the work, and comes back with a recommendation.
- The perceive-decide-act loop: Like a chess player -- perceive the board, decide the best move, act by moving the piece, observe the new board state, repeat. The loop is simple; the intelligence is in the decisions made at each step.

THESIS LINE LOCATION

Beat 2 -- The insight is: an agent is just a model running a loop with tools -- perceive, decide, act, observe, repeat. That simple pattern is behind every AI agent, from simple scripts to complex multi-agent systems.

FRAMEWORK PHRASE

Perceive, decide, act

SPECIFICITY BANK

- Claude Code is itself an AI agent: it perceives your project, decides what to do, acts by running commands, observes the result, and loops
- Tools an agent can have: web search, file read/write, bash commands, API calls, MCP connections
- Nate Herk built \$23,000 in sales from four simple AI agents (documented case study)
- Sub-agents: Claude Code can spawn multiple agent instances for parallel tasks
- Human-in-the-loop: Claude Code permission system is one implementation of this pattern

CONSTRAINTS

- Do not go into specific agent frameworks (Hermes, OpenClaw) -- those are later videos
- Do not explain how to build an agent in this video -- this is the "what is it" video
- Do not go deep on RAG or memory systems -- keep it focused on the perceive-act loop
- Keep the technical depth accessible -- no code in this video

CTA DIRECTION

You know what agents are. Next: AI Rules Explained -- how to control what your agent does and does not do, which is the first thing to define before any agent runs.

PERSONAL ANGLE [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: The first agent you built that actually ran something useful autonomously -- what it did and what it replaced in your workflow.

VULNERABILITY MOMENT [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: An agent that ran autonomously when it should have checked in -- what it did that you did not want, and how you added human checkpoints after.

Note: belongs in Beat 4